

Getting Ready to Sell: Home Prep Checklist

A step-by-step guide for Washington sellers — work top to bottom as your list date approaches.

Buyers decide fast. A home that shows clean, open, and well cared for photographs better, draws more showings, and supports a stronger price. Small effort here pays off at the offer table.

Declutter & Open Up the Space

4–6 weeks out

- ☐ **Declutter every room.** If you have not used it in 6 months, it goes in a box.
- ☐ **Box and store all non-essentials** — off-season clothes, extra dishes, books, décor, collections, paperwork.
- ☐ **Clear surfaces:** countertops, dressers, nightstands, and shelves should be nearly empty. Aim for 2–3 items max per surface.
- ☐ Remove excess furniture. Fewer pieces make every room feel larger — especially important in smaller homes and condos.
- ☐ Thin out closets and cabinets to about half full. Buyers open everything, and packed storage reads as "not enough space."
- ☐ Take down most personal photos and fridge items so buyers can picture themselves living there.
- ☐ Donate, sell, or dispose of what is not coming with you — less to store now and less to move later.

Storage & Movers

4–6 weeks out

- ☐ **Contact movers now for quotes.** Get 2–3 estimates; summer weekends book out weeks ahead.
- ☐ **Price portable storage (PODS, U-Haul U-Box, 1-800-PACK-RAT)** or a small storage unit for your boxed items while the home is on the market.
- ☐ If in a condo or HOA community, check rules on moving hours, elevator reservations, and where a container may sit.
- ☐ Start collecting boxes and packing supplies — label boxes by room as you go.

Repairs & Touch-Ups

3–4 weeks out

- ☐ **Fix anything within budget:** leaky faucets, running toilets, loose handles, sticking doors, cracked outlet covers.
- ☐ Replace burned-out bulbs everywhere; match color temperature (soft white) and use the brightest wattage fixtures allow.
- ☐ Patch nail holes and touch up paint. Repaint bold-color walls a light neutral if budget allows — highest-return fix there is.
- ☐ Re-caulk tubs, showers, and sinks if caulk is stained or peeling.
- ☐ Clean or replace furnace filter; make sure smoke and CO detectors work (required for sale in WA).
- ☐ Ask me before larger projects — not every upgrade pays back at this stage.

Deep Clean

1–2 weeks out

- ☐ Deep clean top to bottom, or hire a one-time cleaning service — usually the best money spent in the whole process.
- ☐ Windows inside and out, tracks included. Light sells homes.
- ☐ Grout, baseboards, light switches, vents, and appliance interiors.
- ☐ Carpets professionally cleaned if stained or holding odors.
- ☐ Neutralize odors at the source (pets, cooking, smoke) — do not just cover with air freshener.

Paperwork to Gather

2–3 weeks out

- ☐ **Seller Disclosure Statement (Form 17)** — I will send this; complete it honestly and thoroughly.
- ☐ **Condo/HOA sellers:** resale certificate, CC&Rs, current dues, and any special assessment info. I will help order these.
- ☐ Appliance manuals, warranties, and receipts for recent repairs or improvements.
- ☐ Average utility costs (buyers ask), plus any service contracts.
- ☐ Keys, fobs, garage remotes, mailbox keys, and gate/storage codes.

While You're on the Market

- ☐ Keep it "show ready" daily: beds made, dishes away, counters clear, quick vacuum.
- ☐ Leave for showings and take pets with you when possible — buyers linger longer in an empty home.
- ☐ Secure valuables, medications, and personal documents out of sight.
- ☐ Say yes to as many showing requests as you can, especially the first two weeks.

Bottom line: less stuff, more light, everything working. Do those three things and your home will stand out from day one.



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